

connected externally, with the media or the companies that want to do business with us.

RC: Your profile mentions that you also created a national distro for Venezuela. So how do you now see it? Do you think that countries need to have their own distributions?

MS: Do you think that there is a need for a national distribution of Linux in India as well?

José : My work was with Canaima, which is the national distribution of Venezuela, before I joined Microsoft. It is what I am passionate about, because it uses many open source technologies. I have been working on Linux for many years and, obviously, on some other models as well. It's a beautiful project in terms of the reach, and I think any technology that democratises access and reach is important. Giving you my personal perspective on this is tricky since I am sitting here as a Microsoft head. But, generally speaking, from Microsoft's perspective, governments have always been very open to the policy of technology including the policy for open source. In the last two weeks, if you look at the conversation we are having in places like the US, we are actually looking into how we can help drive the open source policy. And I think it has to be a win-win scenario where we can help in successfully developing this interest in open source. At the same time, we also believe strongly that our products have immense potential, so whether they are proprietary or not, they are often the best fit in many cases. So we have that balance.

The open source ecosystem is very vague and diverse, which is something that you cannot control. It has always offered thousands of different ways in which people can fix a problem.

Balaji: I have been fairly involved in working with a number of people in India, in C-DAC, NICA, etc. There are some primary questions that I think we need to think about before taking a call on that. It's good to have open source, but we need to maintain some records. For instance, let's assume you build an open source platform and there is no company supporting that code. And we build an operating system on it called X, version 3.1. Twenty years later, the OS has gone to X.x and moved to version 21. At that stage, is the community aware that the code was built on version 3.1? I am just saying that the government or certain bodies need to think about a few more things, because proprietary firms like Microsoft commit to their end users that they will support any version, immaterial of how many versions there are.



Balaji Kesavraj, director-platform strategy & marketing, Microsoft

message for them?

Balaji: Absolutely. We are not saying we have adopted Linux, but we support open source completely. You can run Linux as a first class guest, if you are committed as a first class citizen on our cloud platform. K.Y. Srinivasan, partner architect at Microsoft, is probably the single largest provider of code to the Linux kernel today. He has contributed 20,000 lines of code and he is a Microsoft employee; so that's our commitment with Linux. The things that we are doing are more open in other ways too, not regarding just the source code, but also with regard to the community.

RC: So is there a major change in the environment at Redmond with the change in leadership? Steve Ballmer was never seen as someone who was in love with open source. With Satya Nadella taking over, is there a change or, rather, what is the change?

José : We have seen acceleration in the internal awareness,

like in the engagements (with customers, technologists, etc) and conversations, which Microsoft now feels much more empowered to have. Investments in open source have always been there, and have been there for many years. So that's what I think has

accelerated. We have a fairly mature open source strategy, though it's not perfect, as I mentioned. But we really want to strive towards leadership in many areas (like containers)—that still requires a lot of maturity and many years of discussion, simulation, gathering customers' insights, decision making, etc. I think people are now getting to know what open source is. It's a journey of discovery.

RC: Is there a strategic road map for coming out with an open source project of the scale of Android, which Google rolled out?

José : Something that is already out there is the .NET framework, which is strategic and has the whole ecosystem